

Psalms 81

Open Thy Mouth Wide

Open thy mouth wide, and I will fill it
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Sing aloud unto God our strength: make a joyful noise unto the God of Jacob.
- 2 Take a psalm, and bring hither the timbrel, the pleasant harp with the psaltery.
- 3 Blow up the trumpet in the new moon, in the time appointed, on our solemn feast day.
- 4 For this was a statute for Israel, and a law of the God of Jacob.
- 5 This he ordained in Joseph for a testimony, when he went out through the land of Egypt: where I heard a language that I understood not.
- 6 I removed his shoulder from the burden: his hands were delivered from the pots.
- 7 Thou calledst in trouble, and I delivered thee; I answered thee in the secret place of thunder: I proved thee at the waters of Meribah. Selah.
- 8 Hear, O my people, and I will testify unto thee: O Israel, if thou wilt hearken unto me;
- 9 There shall no strange god be in thee; neither shalt thou worship any strange god.
- 10 I am the LORD thy God, which brought thee out of the land of Egypt: open thy mouth wide, and I will fill it.
- 11 But my people would not hearken to my voice; and Israel would none of me.
- 12 So I gave them up unto their own hearts' lust: and they walked in their own counsels.
- 13 Oh that my people had hearkened unto me, and Israel had walked in my ways!
- 14 I should soon have subdued their enemies, and turned my hand against their adversaries.
- 15 The haters of the LORD should have submitted themselves unto him: but their time should have endured for ever.
- 16 He should have fed them also with the finest of the wheat: and with honey out of the rock should I have satisfied thee.

2 · CONTEXT

A festival psalm calling Israel to joyful worship at an appointed feast, moving quickly from celebration into a prophetic oracle in God's own voice recalling the exodus and Israel's persistent unwillingness to fully trust Him. Henry highlights the tender complaint of a God who freed His people from real bondage only to watch them settle for less than the abundance He offered; MacArthur-style notes underline verse 10's image—an open mouth ready to be filled—as a picture of the trust God still invites.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-5

The call to worship is exuberant: sing aloud, raise a joyful noise, bring out timbrel, harp, and trumpet for the appointed feast. This is described as a statute for Israel rooted in the exodus itself, established 'when Israel went out of Egypt'—worship tied directly to remembered deliverance.

Verse 6-10

God speaks directly, recalling how He removed the burden from Israel's shoulders and freed their hands from hard labor, how He answered them in trouble from the hidden thunder and tested them at the waters of Meribah. The appeal becomes personal and urgent: if only you would listen—no strange god is to be worshiped, for 'I am the Lord your God who brought you out of Egypt; open your mouth wide, and I will fill it.'

Verse 11-16

The tragic turn: my people would not listen, Israel would have none of me, so I gave them over to their own stubborn hearts to walk in their own counsels. The psalm's tone shifts to lament for what could have been: if only they had walked in God's ways, He would have quickly subdued their enemies and fed them with the finest wheat and honey from the rock—abundance forfeited by unbelief, not withheld by God.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

God's invitation to His people is consistently generous—an open mouth He is eager to fill—but that abundance is repeatedly forfeited not by God's reluctance but by human unwillingness to trust and obey Him fully. The psalm holds together festive celebration of past deliverance and sober lament over squandered blessing, refusing to let nostalgia obscure present unfaithfulness.

Application for life today.

Consider where you may be settling for less than what God has actually offered, out of stubbornness or self-reliance rather than any real scarcity on His part. Let verse 10's image challenge your prayer life directly: are you actually 'opening your mouth wide,' asking largely and trusting fully, or praying small out of habit? Use festival or worship moments, as this psalm does, to deliberately recall specific past deliverances as fuel for present trust.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where might you be settling for a smaller measure of God's provision or blessing than He has actually offered (v. 10)?

2. What 'strange god'—a competing source of security or trust—does verse 9 call you to examine in your own life?

3. How does knowing that forfeited blessing in this psalm comes from human unwillingness, not divine withholding (vv. 13–14), change how you view a current unmet longing?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).